Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Edna St. Vincent Millay's "[Oh, oh, you will be sorry for that word!]"

Literary concepts that MIGHT be used by the contestant in a discussion of the speaker's response to the patronizing, condescending, misogyny voiced by the "you" first appearing in the first line of St. Vincent Millay's "[Oh, oh, you will be sorry for that word!]" include

alliteration,
apostrophe,
connotation,
diction,
femme fatale,
ingénue,
interior monologue,
masculine rhyme,
rhyme scheme,
sonnet,
tone, and
synecdoche.

The student should recognize, after spending a bit of time with Millay's poetry, an attitude, a tone, that characterizes some of her poems and that is found in a developing mode in this particular sonnet. The tone that changes, develops, as a response—perhaps as an interior monologue—to what the speaker's husband has said—at least once, but one suspects that this is not an isolated incident—reflects a bitterness; however, it is sarcastically mitigated by a recognition of her duty as a wife: "I shall love you still, *and all of that* (line 7; emphasis added).

At the very least the student should recognize a coyness that is crafted to seem genuine in its immediate responsiveness to the husband's low expectations, which are summarized in his "word": "What a big book for such a little head!" (4). The speaker's unvoiced comeback, "I never again shall tell you what I think" (8), becomes increasingly inauthentic: it is a promise that is followed by a feigned guarantee that he "will not catch [her] reading any more" (10). The speaker's response evolves from a threat to a promise: "I shall be gone" (14) and concludes with words that the beck-and-call days are over: "and you may whistle for me" (14), and there will be no response, no matter his expectations.

The contestant versed in not only the *Handbook*'s contents but also the world through Millay's sometimes barbed perspective might well recognize in the speaker's response the husband's appreciation of the ingénue ***and*** his being deserving of something more toward the *femme fatale*.